

ANNA NAGAR

Purasawalkam » Villivakkam » Kolathur » Nazarathpettai » Pattabiram » Maduravoyal » Koyambedu » Tiruverkadu » Puzhal » Kilpauk » Perambur » Mogappair

Avadi » Ayyappakkam » Tiruninravur » Nerkundram » Moolakadai » Ayanavaram » Retteri » Padi » Ambattur » Tirumullaivoyal » Aminjikarai » Vysarpadi » Red Hills

‘Install electronic display boards at Platform Four’



Platform Four at Avadi railway station. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

ANU NANDHANA M

A good number of express trains are allowed to stop at Platform Four in Avadi railway station. But this platform lacks electronic boards displaying coach numbers.

This is quite inconvenient for the passengers for they have to rush when the train arrives.

It is a safety concern for senior citizens.

The express trains halting at the station include: Thiruvananthapuram-Chennai Central Express (12624), Alappuzha-Chennai Central Express (22640), Chennai Central-Mangaluru Express (12685/12686) and the Tirupati-Chennai Central Garudadri Express (16204).

Avadi is home to impor-

tant establishments of the Ministry of Defence and the Central Reserve Police Force of the Ministry of Home Affairs.

Therefore, a large number of employees working in these establishments are from other States and rely on this station.

I request Southern Railway to do the needful.

Anu Nandhana M is a resident of Avadi.

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READERS WRITE

‘A lacklustre park in Kilpauk’



The park on Medavakkam Tank Road. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

D. RADHAKRISHNAN

Greater Chennai Corporation's children's park adjacent to Institute of Mental Health on Medavakkam Tank Road in Kilpauk is unwelcoming as the green cover is sparse.

Further, it lacks amenities such

as drinking water and toilet facilities. The number of play equipment is also inadequate.

Residents of Sanyasipuram and Kuttiappan Street make use of this recreational space which was inaugurated in August 1999.

D. Radhakrishnan is a resident of Kilpauk

The vacant parcel of land on College Road in Mogappair West. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



‘An unauthorised dumping yard in Mogappair West’

KIRUBA SHANKAR

A vacant plot opposite Mar Gregarious College on College Road in Mogappair West is a health hazard to the public. All kinds of waste including plastic products and con-

struction debris are dumped here. In other words, it has become an illegal dumping yard. The debris contains heavy metals and chemicals that can pollute the soil and the groundwater.

Further, the place is overrun

with vegetation providing a conducive environment for poisonous reptiles.

Complaints to the authorities were to no avail.

Kiruba Shankar is a resident of Mogappair Eri Scheme

‘Telecommunication cables posing a risk’

D. SURESH

Cables of various telecommunication companies are lying unattended across many roads and interior lanes in Avadi. Some are hanging very low. Pedestrians can trip and fall; and it also poses a risk to the safety of motorcyclists. Further, the roads are not restored after cable-laying work.

D. Suresh is a resident of Thirumullaivoyal



A footpath in Thirumullaivoyal. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

You can be our volunteer writer

Dear readers, you can be our volunteer-writer by writing to us about issues and events in your neighbourhood. You should send the write-ups to downtownfeedback@the-hindu.co.in. Letters must carry the contact number



Corrigendum

In the article “Higher secondary status sought for GCC school in Ambattur” dated July 12, 2026 in the Anna Nagar edition of *The Hindu Downtown*, the number of Class 10 boy students that passed out in May 2026 from Chennai High School on Vasuki Street at Cholaipuram in Ambattur was erroneously mentioned as 450.

The correct number is 106, according to a Greater Chennai Corporation official.

The error is regretted.

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Exploration of green campuses in Chennai soon

With a pan-India initiative by Nature Conservation Foundation inviting colleges to create a Campus Biodiversity Register, one can find lists from institutions such as MCC, IIT-M, WCC and Stella Maris making it to iNaturalist, eBird and Season Watch



The sylvan MCC campus.

LIFY THOMAS

The backyard of certain college campuses hardly resemble backyards as we usually understand them: a poky little space, lacklustre, hardly hoofed by human feet. In these colleges, the backyard is an expansive space, supporting an incredible population of furs and feathers; and they pull in human feet given to exploration and documentation of biodiversity.

Classic examples include IIT Madras in Guindy and Madras Christian College in Tambaram. There are also others such as Women's Christian College in Nungambakkam and Stella Maris College in Gopalapuram that lend themselves to making of biodiversity checklists.

Against this green backdrop, Campus Biodiversity Register (CBS) is hugely relevant to Chennai. CBS invites colleges and universities to discover and document the biodiversity on their campuses and build a lasting record of it. An initiative of the Nature on Campus team of the Nature Conservation Foundation (NCF) together with the National Biodiversity Authority, Government of India, the nationwide year-long initiative seeks that students and faculty document biodiversity on their campuses using three citizen science platforms – iNaturalist, eBird and SeasonWatch. WCC, Stella Maris and MCC have doc-

umented the flora, avifauna and fauna on their campuses in the past and brought books on them. From some colleges, the books have also opened their pages to insects. Students of the BSc in Environmental Science and Sustainability and teachers at Azim Premji University in Bengaluru brought out a Campus Biodiversity Register 2024-25 that can be accessed online.

CBR expects these institutions to document their biodiversity with conservation in mind, sustaining endangered species. Besides gaining hands-on experience observing, identifying and documenting species, the participating institutions would be contributing to a global database with their inputs. According to a note on campusbiodiversity.in, by participating one is contributing valuable biodiversity information to global databases as envisioned by the Convention on Biological Diversity while complementing the efforts of the People's Biodiversity Register. The project encourages institutions with just standalone buildings to also sign up for the exercise as biodiversity can be found in the most unexpected places.

There is no fee to participate in this project. Registrations are open till November 2026.

For more details, visit <https://campusbiodiversity.in> or email natureoncampus@ncf-india.org

(MVBB), based in Gopalapuram and run by TTK Group as a service to society, and whenever he receives a call-up from them, he is in attendance at that address the next moment. In April this year, MVBB celebrated its Golden Jubilee.

Shamsudeen elaborates: "As I have a rare blood type, I do not donate blood once in three to four months as many donors do, but donate when there is an emergency, an urgent need for AB Negative. MVBB keeps a record of when I donated blood, and in an emergency, they would call me if I am within the date for donating blood again."

Bookmark this thought: irrespective of whether one's blood group is rare or common, one would do well to be attached to a blood donation organisation so that one gets tuned in to the idea of donating blood as often as they can by virtue of getting timely reminders and urgent call-ups.

Shamsudeen's blood donation tally stands at 22.

As he desired, Shamsudeen's journey as a blood donor has followed the same trajectory as his father's.

(Before proceeding with the how of it, a snapshot of a recent ho-

If you are gripped by a mission to increase the numbers of blood donors, but do not know where to begin, begin at home. Have conversations with your children about your blood donation journey. It sure works: ask the Shaikhs

A leitmotif among blood donation organisations is the increasing difficulty in finding people with "generous veins"; and the solution could strangely be found in the living rooms of households, as illustrated by these two accounts from Chennai of parents inspiring their children to join the cause

Create blood donors at home

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN



Shaikh Shamsudeen and Shaikh Sadaqathullah

nour to the father-son duo. Last month, on World Blood Donors Day, Crescent Blood Donors honoured Shaikh Sadaqathullah and his son Shaikh Shamsudeen for their commitment to blood donation at an event organised at Kavikko Convention Centre in Mylapore. The award was jointly presented by noted film director Ameer Sultan and Ahmed Buhari, trustee of B.S. Abdur Rahman Crescent Institute of Science & Technology)

Besides the commitment to donating blood as often they can and the choice to be attached to MVBB, father and son share their blood type, AB Negative. The blood donation tally of Shaikh Sadaqathullah, 56 years old, stands at 53. As Sadaqathullah notes, a tinge of disappointment slipping into his voice for a fleeting moment, he stopped donating blood due to health concerns.

(A trivia: Sadaqathullah is an amateur radio operator and his call sign is VU2SDU)

Sadaqathullah's blood donation journey was initiated at the Perambur Railway Hospital in 1993 where he donated blood responding to a friend's call. "It was then I realised that my blood group was rare. Any negative blood type is considered rare, and AB Negative is rare even among the negative blood types. Globally, 2 per cent of the population has this blood type. Given this, I have not donated at blood donation camps, only when there was an emergency need for AB Negative, and MVBB would call him."

The interviews were with the father and son duo were conducted separately, and what struck was the similarity not only in the language they used, but also the sentiments they expressed.

There is a lesson there, and probably hope too, for blood donation champions such as Srivatsa Vema from the Federation of Indian Blood Donors Organisation (FIBDO) who has expressed concern over a decreasing number of blood donors.

Bookmark this thought too: if you gripped by a mission to increase the numbers of blood donors, but do not know where to begin, begin at home. Have conversations with your children about your blood donation journey. It sure works: ask the Shaikhs.

COLLECTIVE KINDNESS is a column about efforts by voluntary agencies and individual volunteers to shore up processes by public and private enterprises aimed at bringing personal well-being to people

Get started

There are many organisations that drive blood donation on an everyday basis and also through campaigns. Here are some organisations that can help one get started on blood donation.

- Rotary Central TTK VHS Blood Bank being run at Voluntary Health Services (VHS) in Tharamani. Contact: 044-22542829
- Madras Voluntary Blood Bank (MVBB) at 6, Cathedral Road in Gopalapuram, organises blood donations for people in need, connecting donors with those who need blood. Contact: 9841821997/ 9094039538 / 044-28111403 (Saturday and Sunday are off days)
- Crescent Blood Donors at Crescent college campus in Vandalur. Though located at an institution, outsiders can also donate blood after being screened; the group can be contacted for blood donation needs too. Contact: 9087410874
- Through blood donation drives, New College supports blood bank at government hospitals as well as individuals looking for blood donors. The college does not have a dedicated blood bank, but its administrative office can be contacted at 044-28351269/ 28350386
- For donating blood and to receive blood as donation, contact Federation of Indian Blood Donors at 9381005254
- Direction for Volunteers (D4V) conducts blood donation drives and its efforts help medical establishments such as Voluntary Health Services and Institute of Child Health. For details, WhatsApp D4V at 7448888065
- Lions Blood Bank & Research Foundation is located at 130, Marshalls Road in Egmore. For details, call 044-28414949

A family tradition



R. Ravikumar donating blood on March 17, 2026 for the 106th time.

Nanganallur resident R. Ravikumar would not skip certain schedules, some day-based and others occurring every few months, not for all the tea in China. These schedules largely relate to his passion for cycling, running and donating blood. The unwavering commitment to blood donation has put an enviable tally against his name: 106 blood donations, the last donation made on March 17, 2026 at Sunrays Hospital in Ashok Nagar.

Ravikumar, a retired manager from the Oriental Insurance Company Limited, has never viewed blood donation as a mere act of charity. It has been a family legacy, a service that brings him closer to his father's memory: his father was a blood donor, having donated over 50 times in his lifetime. And Ravikumar traces his iron-clad commitment to blood donation to his late father S. Rengarajan's example as well as simple philosophy, which drives his world view. "Even if we cannot help someone financially, we can always serve the society through our actions without expecting anything in return," his father would often say. Inspired by those words, Ravikumar (whose blood type is B Positive) began do-

nating blood at the age of 23 in 1984, the first donation aimed at helping a colleague's wife who was undergoing surgery. To continue this service, Ravikumar has made staying healthy his top priority through regular marathon runs and long distance cycling, believing physical fitness is the reason that he is still able to answer every call for blood.

Since the age of 56, he has participated in numerous endurance events, earning 85 medals. He is also an active member of several blood donation groups in Chennai, continuing to respond to urgent need for donors.

Among the 106 donations, one will always remain etched in his memory. In 2019, after donating blood for a six-year-old cancer patient from Odisha, the child's parents insisted on meeting him. "I told them I had done nothing special, but they still wanted to thank me," he recalls.

The scene that followed will make anyone go teary-eyed. They bowed in gratitude, a gesture that deeply moved him and reaffirmed his belief that compassion knows no language.

While Ravikumar's father donated blood over 50 times, and today his brother R. Ramesh has crossed 60 donations.

What began as one man's quiet belief in selfless service has now grown into a powerful family tradition.

The list of hospitals Ravikumar has donated to include Apollo Hospital in Greams Road, Nandanam Apollo Cancer Speciality Hospital, Vijaya Hospital, Miot Hospital, Egmore Children's Hospital, Adyar Cancer Institute, VHS Blood Bank, various Rotary Club camps, Railway Hospital in Perambur, Sevalaya in Thirunindravoor, SIMS Hospital, Chrompet Government Hospital, Rajaji Government Hospital, Sunrays Hospital and WCCG blood donation camps.

Ravikumar is 65 years old now, usually considered the maximum age at which one could donate blood. Exceptions to that rule do exist; and Ravikumar seems set to be an exception.

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

Want to understand your city? Try travelling from one end of it to the other. On July 18, fifteen children from the Narikurava community in Pallavaram had the privilege of doing that kind of cross-city travel thanks to "Toxic Tour" organised by Agai - Theatre of Voices in collaboration with Vettiver Collective and Chennai Climate Action Group. These children were being introduced to the industrial north of Chennai where tall chimneys mark the skyline. For the first time, they were setting eyes on thermal power plants, oil refineries and the Adani Port.

At every turn, the children learnt how development was impacting people's everyday lives; more specifically, breathing polluted, toxic air into those lives. This was no awareness tour. The children were wearing the researcher's hat, filing away information for Enge Engal Nadhigal (Where Are Our Rivers?), a year-long puppetry production that has children taking centre stage as storytellers, writing their own scripts.

Architect of this initiative, Agai - Theatre of Voices is a young Gen-Z Chennai collective that seeks to provide a collaborative platform for their own (that is, other members of Gen Z) to work towards social and environmental justice. The philosophy is hardly accidental. It mirrors the journeys of its founders, Tittu (as he prefers to be known) and Nambi Srinivas, both trained social workers whose paths first crossed at the Madras School of Social Work. While Tittu went on to pursue a postgraduate degree at Christ University, Bengaluru and Nambi specialised in community development, theatre became the language that united them long before Agai formally came into existence in 2023. For Tittu, social work dismantled not only career choices, but inherited beliefs. For one, "it made me question the idea that we have to speak for commun-



Children set to *script change*

A year-long puppetry production titled "Enge Engal Nadhigal" by Agai - Theatre of Voices has children from a Narikurava community in Pallavaram taking centre stage as storytellers. As part of this initiative, the children were taken on a tour of the industrial north Chennai on July 18 to understand the negative impact development can have on people's everyday lives and bring that insight into their stories

ities." That conviction deepened after Tittu was selected for Kanthari, the international leadership programme in Thiruvananthapuram, where he was among only three participants from India. There, meeting Sabriye Tenberken, founder of the first blind school in Tibet, re-moulded Agai's ideological compass. "We completely reject the phrase 'voice of the voiceless'," he says. "Everyone already has a voice. What people need is someone willing to listen." And that is Agai's guiding principle now, one informing its initiatives including the programme for the children from the Narikurava community in

The spirit of collaboration

Agai - Theatre of Voices works alongside organisations such as Vettiver Collective, Chennai Climate Action Group and Open House, sharing skills, resources and campaigns rather than guarding ownership.

It is also one of the organisations behind March for Marshlands, a rally scheduled for July 25 at Besant Nagar Beach. Bringing together more than 20 organisations and citizens across Chennai, the rally calls for the conservation of the city's marshlands and stronger action against encroachments and ecologically unsound construction projects, particularly the proposed Mammalam Reservoir project.

Agai also runs a tribal education programme in the Nilgiris, supports digital comics on child rights, operates the Agai Stellar Band that produces music around environmental themes, and conducts youth outreach programmes that introduce urban students to tribal communities through shared experiences instead of surveys and statistics.

Pallavaram.

Again has been working with these children for two months now. No rigid lesson plans; not compulsory practice sessions. Much of the time has simply been spent sitting with the children, making puppets and just talking. Only after that comfort began to emerge did stories begin to surface.

"Once we gave them the puppets, they started speaking automatically," recalls Tittu. "Nothing was prompted. We did not expect it. One child spoke about forests. Another spoke about the River Ganga, even though she has never seen it. The puppets became a space where they could say things adults never asked them."

Those stories will eventually become Enge Engal Nadhigal. Over the coming year, the children themselves will shape the script, perform it and later travel to different parts of Chennai, and eventually other cities using theatre to tell audiences about disappearing rivers, environmental degradation and the worlds they inhabit.

The process matters as much as the performance. "Getting children to stay with us for even one hour is difficult," says Tittu. "One place they do not want to go is school. So we do not recreate school. We do not ask them to sit quietly and listen." Instead, Agai asks adults to do something considerably harder: to listen.

Says Srinivas: "We are simply doing small things and going with the flow." That "flow" has become Agai's operational term.

For Srinivas Nambi and Tittu, going with the flow would mean creating "a forest-based learning space where children enjoy education. We do not want them to adapt to a system. We want to build a system that grows with them." Part of that would be photography programmes, football coaching for tribal youth and creative learning rooted in local knowledge rather than imposed ideas. It is an ambitious vision for a collective that admits financial uncertainty remains its greatest challenge.



During one of the sessions.

VISTAS starts AI varsity in Thiruvananthapuram



Sridhar Vembu, co-founder of Zoho Corporation, inaugurates the Artificial Intelligence (AI) vertical university campus in Thiruvananthapuram. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Vel's Institute of Science, Technology, and Advanced Studies (VISTAS) opened an Artificial Intelligence (AI) vertical university campus on East Coast Road.

Sridhar Vembu, chief scientist and co-founder of Zoho Corporation, inaugurated the campus in the presence of Ishari K. Ganesh, chancellor, Vel's University, and Ahmed Mir Hashim Khoori, a board member of the Emirates Airline Foundation.

The campus features AI-enabled classrooms, smart learning systems, advanced laboratories, innovation studios, collaborative learning spaces, and digital libraries.

A major highlight of the campus is its Industry-Academia Centres of Excellence, established in collaboration with Intel Unnati, TCS iON, Microsoft, and Oracle Academy, which will provide students with hands-on exposure to AI, cloud computing, high-performance computing, and other emerging

technologies.

Delivering the inaugural address, Sridhar Vembu appreciated the vision behind the new campus and emphasised the importance of building indigenous technologies.

He encouraged students to develop deep technical expertise, embrace lifelong learning, solve real-world problems through innovation, and contribute meaningfully to India's technological advancement.

A Memorandum of Understanding was signed between Vel's University and the Dubai Airlines Group for aviation training, internships, faculty exchange, skill development, and international career opportunities for students.

The varsity will also soon sign an MoU with Zoho Corporation to collaborate in Artificial Intelligence, emerging technologies, research, innovation, entrepreneurship, skill development, and industry-academia initiatives, added the release.



Artist Semmozhi. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Debut exhibition of young artist

Every artist remembers the moment when a blank canvas became a world of endless possibilities.

For young artist Semmozhi Navaladi Raja that moment has blossomed into a solo art exhibition titled 'Genesis - Debut Collection'.

The paintings are not just colours, but hours of observation, imagination, patience, and perseverance. Semmozhi has chosen to express her thoughts and emotions through art, drawing inspiration from serene landscapes and natural wonders.

The exhibition can be viewed on July 19 at Art Cube Gallery, Second Street, Elango Nagar, Virugambakkam, from 10 a.m. to 9 p.m.

The exhibition marks the beginning of a young artist's journey and is the result of the support of her family members and mentors, said a release.

The exhibition also features works celebrating India's rich artistic heritage.

Club partners for hair donation drive

Two young donors –Nithara Nair and Rachel Janette Madhan – who donated their hair to help create wigs for individuals undergoing cancer treatment, were presented with certificates of appreciation as part of the ongoing hair donation drive by Inner Wheel Club (IWC) Chennai Wisteria.

Bodycraft Salon has partnered with IWC Chennai Wisteria as the official hair donation centre. The collected hair will be donated to

The Cherian Foundation, where it will be used to create wigs for cancer patients, helping restore their confidence and bringing hope during their treatment journey, said a release. IWC Chennai Wisteria President Nikitha M. Babu and Danushya, Managing Partner, Tusk Hospitality - Franchise of Bodycraft Salon, Anna Nagar took part.

Bodycraft is at Shop 9/175, 11th Main Rd, A E Block, Block AE, Anna Nagar.



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Exhibition of silk saris in Anna Nagar

D. Ravi Silks is holding a silk expo at Kanchi Residency, Anna Nagar, featuring exquisite silk saris combining authenticity and quality.

D Ravi began his career in 1987 as a weaver. Later, he started a small enterprise with six weavers at his home. In 1998, he opened a store in Kancheepuram.

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cheepuram silk saris, with traditional designs inspired by Kancheepuram's temples and the dreams of present-generation women.

The saris woven by more than 250 weavers reflect timeless elegance, exceptional craftsmanship, and the rich heritage of Kancheepuram silk, said a release.

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At Ashraya School for Special Children in Perambur.
PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Tree planting drive at school in Perambur

The Southern Railway Women's Headquarters Organisation (SRWHQO) organised a tree plantation drive at Ashraya School for Special Children, run by SRWHQO, in Perambur recently. Over 200 saplings of flowers like jasmine, coral jasmine, and hibiscus and fruit-bearing trees were distributed to the students and staff of the school. Sonia Singh, president, SRWHQO, took

part in the event.

A tree planting drive was also held at Blossom Creche & Day Care Centre, run by SRWHQO. On the occasion, refreshments were provided to the students and staff.

Ashraya school, established in February 1993, offers vocational training programme for persons with special needs. The skill training includes: making envelopes, paper bags, and candles.



Chennai Primary School in Mogappair. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Poster competition on environment held



Test your knowledge in geography

The Indian National Cartographic Association (INCA), Tamil Nadu chapter, invites school and college students to participate in the Regional and National Quiz Competition. Designed to encourage geographical knowledge, map-reading skills, current affairs, environmental awareness, and an understanding of geospatial technologies, the quiz will offer participants a platform to demonstrate their knowledge while fostering scientific curiosity and teamwork, said a release.



The event will be conducted in two phases: in phase 1, an online quiz would be conducted at the respective schools of the partici-

pants; and phase 2 at a venue in the city.

Registration and participation fee is ₹100. Participant certificate will be provided and first three prizes will be awarded.

Through workshops, seminars, competitions, and outreach programmes, INCA creates awareness about the importance of maps and geospatial science in education, research, environmental management, disaster mitigation, and sustainable development.

For details, email sujathageobwc@gmail.com or contact P. Sujatha, secretary, INCA Tamil Nadu Chapter at 9840182666

Investiture ceremony



At KRM Public School. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

KRM Public School conducted its investiture ceremony for its student council body recently. According to a press release, Major V. Saranya, Officer Commanding, 1 TN Girls Battalion NCC, Engineering Medical Corps, conferred the leadership badges to the newly-elected office bearers, while the outgoing council members handed over the flags and placards to the newly-elected members.

Following the flag-hoisting cere-

mony, Major V. Saranya received the ceremonial salute from the school's uniformed units, including NCC, Scouts & Guides, RSP, and JRC.

She congratulated the cadets of all four NCC units and presented 'A' certificates to the qualifying cadets. In her address, she shared her experience of a decade of service and offered tips to the newly-elected prefectorial body like "Serve Before Self", "Keep the team with you", "Be a model for others".

The event also featured cultural performances. Parents of the newly elected office bearers were invited to the event.

Thayumanaswamy, CEO of KRM Public School, congratulated the newly elected office bearers and appreciated their willingness to accept responsibility and serve the school community with commitment, discipline, and integrity. He encouraged them to uphold the values of leadership and become role models for their fellow students.

The Alliance Club of Chennai Super Kings and Goodwill Trust, with the support of Nature Research Foundation, conducted a poster creation competition at Chennai Primary School, Mogappair, recently. The theme was environment protection and conservation. According to a press release, 85 students, took part.

The aim of the event was to spread awareness on the importance of sustainable living to protect environment, adds the release.

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